COMPLETING TASKS INDEPENDENTLY		
Classroom behaviour	**Links to working memory**	**Strategies**
To move on to the next step in an activity, needs frequent prompts by teaching staff	• The learner may struggle to remember several steps of a task if instructions for a task are only given verbally • Lengthy tasks with new or unfamiliar content may overload the working memory • Lack of prior knowledge places additional demands on working memory	• Simplify tasks – break down into separate independent steps (p78) • Use visual prompts • Use simple checklists or a flow chart to identify each step in a sequence • Use diagrams with key elements of task depicted by colour or picture cue • Review each step as completed, adjusting demands of task if necessary • Prompt with questions to keep focus on task, eg 'What sentence are you going to write?' 'Which word is missing to complete your sentence?' • Link steps with familiar or meaningful experiences – rather than introducing topic to whole class and then taking out learners who need additional explanation, sometimes it would be beneficial to 'pre-teach' a topic before it is introduced to the whole class • Parents/carers can also be cued in to class topics

		to help prepare learners in advance
Frequently asks for help	• Sign of poor working memory capacity (p71) • Few strategies for independent working • Working memory overload in the task	• More support in planning stage – check understanding and break down into smaller steps • Use spidergram to gather ideas and number points • Correct topic word spellings before drafting • Develop learner's range of spelling strategies, eg highlighting letter patterns, use personal dictionary, target high frequency words on a treasury tag, mnemonics, rhymes, rules • Place with a 'memory buddy'
Abandons activities before completion – the learner gives up, forgetting what to do, sometimes switching attention to another activity or distracting others	• Common consequence of working memory failure	• Monitor and pre-empt by asking the learner what s/he is doing and what s/he intends to do next • Task may need to be repeated and possibly modified (p75) • Encourage learner to request repetition of information/instruction • 'Say it back' – the learner repeats the instructions or talks through steps of activity. This helps the learner to recall and strengthen her/his grasp of a task • Partner learner with a classmate who has good working memory skills (p80)
Frequently stops during lengthy activities or those involving multiple steps - loses place in complicated	• Forgets some or all of information required to complete task or activity • Cannot remember and so does not	• Break down task into small steps, each achieved before moving on to next step • Intersperse a demanding task with an easier,

activities	follow multi-step instructions (p70) • Cannot remember the words in a sentence s/he is attempting to write (p70) • Low working memory affects ability to carry out multi-step instructions (p70)	procedural one • Allow more time • Reduce the amount of writing required by offering alternative methods of recording, eg filming, audio recording, working with a partner who scribes • New information should correspond to previously acquired knowledge • Review topic before activity (p76)
Forgets how to continue an activity that was previously started, despite teacher explanation	• The learner needs to be 'cued in' and may struggle to take in an explanation that relies on easy retrieval of prior knowledge	• Work on previous example together or link with a 'buddy' until the learner gradually becomes more independent • Be prepared to repeat the task, to familiarize with the aims, modifying and simplifying the language of instructions
Benefits from continued teacher support during lengthy activities, especially written tasks	• Too many steps to the task to retain in memory • Learner may not know how to use writing aids to support memory • Difficulties in the past may have led to 'learned helplessness'	• Encourage learner's independence through awareness of preferred learning styles and strategies to support memory • Try Clicker 5 program for writing support to reduce working memory load - pre-enter topic words - pre-enter high frequency words • Use word prediction, eg Co-writer • Use writing frames
Not able to focus during	• Concentration may be affected by	• Create a supportive physical environment – consider seating in relation to teacher

activities	demands of task causing working memory overload	• Reduce distraction with a work station for complex tasks • Use picture prompts or sequence of photographs to match activity plan • Use clear visual images/uncluttered layout on task sheet • Draw on learner's long-term memory of personal experiences to make the activity meaningful
Depends on neighbour to remind them of the current task	• Not actively listening when the instructions are given • Learner is masking problems with understanding or memory overload • Difficulties in the past may have led to 'learned helplessness'	• Ensure that the learner is ready and listening to instructions – minimize distraction by alternative seating • Encourage learner to use simple step guide to build independence and confidence • Jot down important notes on a desk top whiteboard • Note down a number, spelling or use a picture cue as a reminder

DIFFICULTIES REMEMBERING OR PROCESSING SPOKEN INFORMATION		
Classroom behaviour	**Links to working memory**	**Strategies**
Puts hand up to answer a question but forgets what s/he intended to say when asked	• Difficulty retrieving and producing spoken information • Difficulty holding on to thoughts under pressure • Easily distracted by what others say while waiting for her/his turn to speak • Losing track of an argument or stages in an experiment	• Ask the learner straight away before s/he forgets • Repeat the question or previous point made in class discussion to give learner time to answer • Forewarn when the learner will be asked to answer so that s/he has time to prepare • Help by jotting key ideas down on whiteboard – flow chart with key ideas, pictures cues, mind mapping, timelines etc • Ask a teaching assistant to draw the picture cues while class teacher addresses the class
Does not respond or is reluctant to answer when asked direct questions	• Questions may be too lengthy, grammatically complex or unfamiliar • Difficulty processing verbal information – weak memory for information just heard • Cannot recall and order ideas under pressure • Expectation of producing clear and concise answer becomes a barrier	• Use name first to gain attention • Ask question and allow time for response, eg count the seconds it takes the learner to process the instruction/question and adjust the way you ask the question, slowing speech and reducing words • Simplify structure of sentences (p77) • Tailor specific questions to learner • Ask learner to repeat instructions to check understanding
Does not follow classroom instructions accurately, eg carries out some but not all	• Learner may not be ready to listen to instructions	• Try two step instructions, using demonstration and non-verbal cues for extra emphasis

steps in an instruction	• Easily distracted • Too many instructions given at once	• Give instructions with a simple grammatical structure and meaningful or familiar content
Raises hand but gives inappropriate or incorrect answers	• Weak memory for information just heard • Difficulty gathering and processing thoughts in order to express them clearly • Unable to hold on to thoughts until picked to answer a question because of distraction • Losing track of an argument or stages in an experiment • The learner may have formed an answer in her/his mind and continues to think of this even though the lesson has moved on	• Ask the learner straight away before s/he forgets • Give warning of when a question is coming up • Return to learner, summarizing the argument or content so far to refresh memory and facilitate answer or comment • Use visual prompt/diagram/flow chart to 'track back'
Unable to explain what s/he should be doing in a particular activity when asked	• Sign of low working memory • Changing from one activity to another may be difficult – the learner may be competent and supported doing a task kinaesthetically but have difficulties switching to formal explanation	• Allow time to gather thoughts • Recap earlier steps • Ask 'memory buddy' to prompt • Encourage use of memory aids • Give time to express ideas as repetition can strengthen memory

Requires regular repetition of instructions	• Learner may not be able to remember instructions when given verbally • Indicates working memory overload	• Requires careful monitoring by teacher • Instructions appropriately structured to match working memory of learner (pp73-4) • Reduce number of instruction steps and possibly make instructions memorable by using actions (p76) • Structure task to include multisensory activities • Repeat instructions but ask the leaner to 'say it back' – when the leaner puts the instruction into her/his own words, understanding can be checked • Shorten instructions – reduce number of steps • Simplify language of instruction, eg in vocabulary and phrasing • From seven to eight years, learner can be encouraged to use 'rehearsal' strategies, repeating silently or aloud a small amount of verbal information to prolong short-term memory • Develop rehearsal through memorizing a simple message, saying it over and over before 'delivering' it in speech to another teacher or class

LITERACY TASKS		
Classroom behaviour	**Links to working memory**	**Strategies**
When reading, mixes up material inappropriately, eg incorrectly combines parts from two sentences rather than reading each one accurately	• Reading difficulties may arise from visual tracking problems – this should be investigated further if appropriate • Place keeping difficulties because the learner cannot remember how far s/he has got with the task (sorting information) while working on a challenging activity, eg processing writing, counting or physical actions simultaneously, leading to memory overload	• Use a tracking guide • Monitor or test eyesight and coordination if difficulties suspected • Use wider lines to avoid writing becoming obscured • Present information clearly, well spaced and without unnecessary information making the page look too 'busy' • Use different colour pen to make each line or topic area stand out
Incorrectly repeats the same response when writing, eg by writing the same word twice in a sentence	• Writing is a complex task taxing the working memory – words inserted, repeated or omitted can be a sign of working memory overload or motor memory difficulties as the learner fails to keep track of progress, especially if copying from the whiteboard • Incomplete recall may also indicate that the learner remembers what s/he wants to write at the beginning of the sentence but forgets the rest • Poor fine motor skills make writing effortful • Errors occur when focusing on handwriting while also trying to	• Encourage learner to proof read and check through once ideas are written • Encourage prior planning to help with a systematic approach for the learner to work through small steps • Offer desk copies if learner needs to copy extensive notes or objectives from the whiteboard • Avoid unnecessary copying of long date from whiteboard – use short form of date • Careful monitoring by teacher to include asking the learner what s/he intends to do next – the act of repeating important information (rehearsal) can promote storing of information in working memory (pp71-2)

	remember meaning and formulate the next sentence • Learners with poor working memory often lose track of what they have done and what has yet to be completed	
Requires support for effective use of memory aids such as useful spellings	• If memory aids are a distance from the learner's desk s/he may not use spontaneously • Learners often need demonstration, guidance and reminders of how to use and make a habit of using memory aids	• Encourage use of ICT to facilitate easy reference with word banks at a click • Familiarize learners with location of memory aids and make frequent references to a poster or wall chart • Revise memory aids occasionally to ensure they are used – have close to hand and regularly remind learner to use them (p81) • Use target high frequency words drawn from learner's own writing printed and well spaced on clear, uncluttered card – place on desk or inside exercise book • Personal spelling lists, high frequency words or topic words can be entered on Clicker 5 grids, printed and folded into a 'Toblerone' shape for easy reference • Encourage use of long-term memory class strategies, eg acronyms such as CFSS (capital letters, full stops, spellings, sense in sentences) or VCOP (vocabulary, connectives, openers, punctuation) • Ask learners to add words to a prepared list and note their own strategies for remembering (p88)
Needs regular reminders of	• Writing poses particular challenges for	• Use of three to six picture sequences with space below

each step in a written task	the learner with low working memory • If writing skills insecure, the challenge is increased	to write simple caption can aid the planning process - see writing frames information in the Primary and Secondary IDP for SLCN and dyslexia • Use learner's own drawings or photos to show a sequence of steps
Is making poor progress in literacy and maths	• Weaknesses in both subjects can be a warning sign of low memory capacity	• Track and monitor progress in both subjects • Investigate learner's strengths and weaknesses in verbal or visual-spatial short-term and working memory